

Alan Nguyen Pham

Mechanical R&D | Soft Robotics | Computational Design
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Mechanical engineering Ph.D. candidate developing inverse computational mechanism design for soft robotic morphing surfaces that become dynamic 3D forms, including wave-like motion and complex morphing behavior. Targeting mechanical R&D roles in morphing systems, compliant mechanisms, inverse design, and simulation-guided physical prototyping.

Research Focus

Soft robotics; morphing surfaces; inverse computational mechanism design; dynamic 3D surface transformation; wave-like physical systems; compliant mechanisms; constraint-based design; adaptive interfaces.

Education

Doctor of Philosophy, Mechanical Engineering

Worcester Polytechnic Institute, Worcester, MA

Expected 2027

Advisors: Dr. Pratap Rao and Dr. Cagdas Onal

Master of Science, Mechanical Engineering

California State University, Long Beach, Long Beach, CA

2022

Advisor: Dr. Allen Teagle-Hernandez

Bachelor of Science, Mechanical Engineering

California State University, Maritime Academy, Vallejo, CA

2019

Advisor: Dr. Tomas Oppenheim

Awards

NSF NRT Future of Robots in the Workplace – Research and Development (FORW-RD) Fellowship

2024

WPI Intercollegiate Soft Robotics Competition – 1st Place

2024

Research Experience

Worcester Polytechnic Institute, Worcester, MA

Graduate Researcher – NanoEnergy Lab and Soft Robotics Lab

Aug 2023 – Present

Advisors: Dr. Pratap Rao and Dr. Cagdas Onal

- Built a soft-robotic morphing-surface platform that produces dynamic 3D forms including single/double domes, bilayer overhangs, traveling waves, and object transport from modular pneumatic cell assemblies.
- Reassembled the same cell family into planar and cylindrical mechanism layouts for continuum bending/grasping, 200 mm peristaltic crawling, and self-rolling locomotion.
- Created Wavevis through iterative AI-assisted development, specifying target-shape behavior, evaluating generated geometry/UI states, and refining a public computational-design environment for lattice geometry, connector constraints, opposite-pair motion constraints, and variable pair-angle shape studies.
- Validating simulation-derived linkage geometry, connector constraints, and kinematic shape generation through rapid physical prototype iteration for scalable pneumatic morphing-surface systems.
- Developing FluxCell, a scalable pneumatic-mechanical cell architecture for single-inlet pressure distribution through self-sealing snap-fit inter-cell connections and magnet/electropermanent-magnet control of individual PneuNet airflow.

NASA L' SPACE (NPWEE), Tempe, AZ

Soft Robotics Graduate Researcher – Project SELENE

Aug 2025 – Present

- Advanced Project SELENE, a multidisciplinary exploration-robotics effort developing adaptable, resilient robotic systems for extreme and remote environments, including beyond-Earth mission concepts.
- Developed a modular cable-driven soft robotic arm concept for terrain navigation and regolith sample collection in hard-to-reach exploration settings.
- Refined the “Spirobs” arm design by integrating triple-cable actuation with an elastic braided-steel backbone for multidirectional bending, mechanical compliance, dust-resistant operation, and reduced maintenance.
- Led CAD updates, fabrication planning, 3D-printing decisions, assembly strategy, and structured test/evaluation planning while guiding undergraduate teammates and coordinating with NASA subject matter experts.

Sandia National Laboratories, Albuquerque, NM**June 2025 – Aug 2025***Graduate Research Intern – Nonlinear Mechanics and Dynamics (NOMAD) Research Institute*

- Co-developed a NOMAD parameter study quantifying how finite-element setup choices affect nonlinear-dynamics predictions for an electromechanical ratcheting mechanism with intermittent contact, friction, springs, and pawl-gear interactions.
- Built comparable analytical, MATLAB multibody, and finite-element submodels for pin-spring-pawl, pin-pawl, and pawl-gear interactions under haversine shock and sinusoidal vibration.
- Ran structured sweeps across momentum-balance iterations (1–100), mesh density, and processor count (50–250%) to separate physical mechanism response from solver and modeling sensitivity.
- Identified sensitivity regimes in which pin-spring-pawl models converged while pin-pawl and pawl-gear cases showed contact/friction divergence, mesh-related lock-up, and environment-dependent sensitivity.
- Presented final results showing that simulation sensitivity appears at submodel scale, informing more defensible setup choices before full assembly-level ratcheting studies.

Worcester Polytechnic Institute, Worcester, MA**Aug 2023 – Present***NSF NRT FORW-RD Fellow and Trainee*

- Selected as an NSF NRT FORW-RD trainee in an interdisciplinary program on robotic interfaces and assistants for future workplaces spanning robotics, mechanical engineering, computer science, materials, business, humanities, and social sciences.
- Connected doctoral research to virtual training, soft robotic teleoperation, compliant interaction, and robotic systems for high-skill physical tasks.
- Developed broader-impact framing for robotics and AI systems that operate near people, emphasizing workplace adoption, trust, training, and responsible deployment.
- Secured a \$1,000 grant supporting equipment, travel, and professional-development costs.

Worcester Polytechnic Institute, Worcester, MA**Aug 2023 – Dec 2023***Research Assistant – Cognitive Medical Technology Laboratory*

- Fabricated and assembled low-cost open-source actuation hardware for concentric tube continuum robots, a miniaturized robot class for precise navigation in constrained spaces and minimally invasive surgery.
- Contributed to an accessible CTR research platform with easy-to-source components, bills of materials, assembly instructions, and guided learning materials for early graduate students.
- Integrated actuation hardware, MATLAB forward kinematics, and optical-tracking experiments to validate end-effector displacement.
- Coordinated sourcing, fabrication, and assembly across WPI's Cognitive Medical Technology Lab, PracticePoint, and Innovation Studio for two complete CTR systems.

California State University, Long Beach, Long Beach, CA**Sept 2022 – Aug 2023***Research Assistant – Multiscale Mechanics of Materials Group**Advisor: Dr. Mortaza Saeidi-Javash*

- Built a literature foundation for a flexible-electronics research program covering printed and conformal sensors, 2D nanomaterial inks, and wearable human-machine-interface devices.
- Synthesized fabrication approaches across inkjet, screen, aerosol-jet, extrusion, and direct-ink-write printing using graphene, MXene, MoS₂, thermoelectric, and piezoelectric material systems.
- Evaluated sensitivity, selectivity, response time, mechanical compliance, and durability of flexible physical, chemical, and biosensors for soft robotics, structural health monitoring, and wearable systems.
- Collaborated with graduate researchers on a direct-ink-write temperature sensor printed on a flexible PET substrate.

California State University, Long Beach, Long Beach, CA**April 2021 – July 2022***Graduate Researcher – Violin Acoustics and Structural Dynamics**Advisor: Dr. Allen Teagle-Hernandez*

- Completed a master's thesis translating perceived violin quality into measurable vibroacoustic features, linking structural design, harmonic balance, frequency response, and performer/listener perception.
- Designed a controlled comparison of high- and low-cost modern violins, standardizing strings and fittings while documenting top plate, bridge, f-hole, bass bar, sound post, and tailpiece variables.
- Built a LabVIEW/NI data-acquisition workflow with PCB accelerometers, an array microphone, and an impulse modal hammer; collected 67-point top-plate maps and anechoic-chamber acoustic measurements.
- Linked FFT-derived violin response features to modal balance and perceived tone.

California State University, Maritime Academy, Vallejo, CA*Undergraduate Researcher – Cross-Flow Tidal Turbine***Sept 2018 – May 2019***Advisor: Dr. Tomas Oppenheim*

- Conceptualized a Darrieus cross-flow tidal turbine, defined rotor geometry and build constraints, and selected 3D-printed blades with fiberglass coating as the manufacturing approach.
- Verified performance through water-tunnel power assessment and ANSYS structural analysis, evaluating blade and hub stresses under hydrodynamic loading and documenting operation around 25 rpm.
- Fabricated a full-scale prototype using additive manufacturing and sheet-metal forming informed by scaled water-tunnel experiments.

Publications and Research Outputs

- Pham, A. N., Rao, P., & Onal, C. D. (2026). Manuscript in prep.: *Reconfigurable Sarrus-linkage cells for multifunctional soft robots*.
- Pham, A. N. (2026). *Wavevis: inverse computational design environment for modular robotic surface mechanisms* [Public AI-assisted target-shape, constraint-analysis, and mechanism-design tool].
- Pham, A. N. (2026). *FluxCell pneumatic-mechanical robotic-cell system* [Research platform for self-sealing snap-fit single-inlet pressure distribution, simulation-guided linkage and connector design, and magnet/electropermanent-magnet PneuNet flow control].
- Winston, S., Pham, A., Bahr, B., Singh, A., Schumann, C., Flicek, R., Grutzik, S., Kuether, R. J., & Vemaganti, K. (2025). *Quantifying the Effect of Non-Physical Parameters on the Nonlinear Dynamics of an Electromechanical Ratcheting Mechanism*. Accepted to IMAC, A Conference and Exposition on Structural Dynamics.
- Bonofiglio, K. (2023). *Making Concentric Tube Robots More Accessible: An Open-Source Platform with Easy-to-Source Components and Guided Learning Materials* [Master's thesis, Worcester Polytechnic Institute]. Research contributor to open-source CTR hardware assembly and validation support.
- Pham, A., & Teagle Hernandez, A. (2022). *Structural Properties and Perceived Acoustic Quality of Modern Violins* (Publication No. 29065875) [Master's thesis, California State University, Long Beach]. ProQuest Dissertations and Theses Global.

Professional Experience**Worcester Polytechnic Institute, Worcester, MA***Teaching Assistant***Aug 2023 – Present**

- Developed learning activities for Stress Analysis, Statics, and Computer Aided Design with professors and teaching teams.
- Led weekly conference sessions and office hours for 90+ student groups, translating difficult engineering material into interactive problem-solving sessions.
- Designed hands-on learning sessions and guided students in connecting classroom mechanics concepts to physical models and engineering judgment.

NLS Lighting, Carson, CA*Mechanical Engineer***April 2022 – July 2023**

- Led design-to-release luminaire product improvements across thermal testing, IP testing, FEA static simulation, fabrication, assembly, and installation support.
- Produced complete product design packages, including 2D drawings, bills of materials, engineering change orders, installation instructions, and application documentation.
- Collaborated with Washington, DC stakeholders to develop a retrofit kit for upgrading more than 75,000 street and alley lights to energy-efficient LEDs as part of a multi-million-dollar Smart Street Lighting project.

Hubbell, City of Industry, CA*Mechanical Engineer Intern***May 2021 – Aug 2021**

- Managed fixture assembly and DLC V5.1 certification planning, reducing test cost and labor while accounting for SKU quantities and sales volume.
- Performed impact testing and FEA validation on luminaire assemblies, checking bracket, lens, and LED-PCB designs in Solid Edge.
- Supported launch of the Prevent vandal-resistant luminaire series through baseline testing, part sourcing, and assembly coordination with new product design teams.

Academy Inc., Montebello, CA**July 2019 – Aug 2020***Mechanical Design Engineer*

- Implemented parametric product and pricing configurations, reducing design and quoting time.
- Engineered shade sails, awnings, and tensioned fabric structures for manufacturability and field installation.
- Managed projects from site measurements and material specifications through coordination and scope execution.

American Metal Bearing Company, Garden Grove, CA**May 2019 – June 2019***Mechanical Engineer Intern*

- Optimized thrust, line-shaft, stern-tube, and strut bearing components using SolidWorks/Abaqus FEA, reducing material and labor cost.
- Coordinated manufacturing flow for line-shaft spherical bearings from rough casting through inspection, finishing, packaging, and shipment.
- Revised bearing-component drawings under Engineering Change Requests while maintaining GD&T standards.

Technical Skills

Mechanical design	SolidWorks, Onshape, PTC Creo, FEA review, GD&T-aware drawings, BOMs, ECOs, DFM, assembly planning, fixture design, prototype iteration.
Soft robotics	Pneumatic actuation, compliant mechanisms, continuum robots, modular soft robots, morphing surfaces, dynamic surface prototypes, simulation-guided robotic prototyping.
Software	CUBIT, Sierra/SolidMechanics, ParaView, MATLAB, Simulink Simscape Multibody, Abaqus, Ansys FEA, Python, C/C++, ROS2, LabVIEW, Minitab, MS Office; AI-assisted design and web-tool prototyping.
Experiments	Modal testing, vibroacoustic measurement, FFT-based signal analysis, anechoic-chamber testing, optical tracking, pressure/force/displacement characterization, design of experiments.
Hardware	3D printing, laser cutting, soldering, Arduino, Raspberry Pi, National Instruments DAQ, strain gages, thermocouples, pressure sensors, force testing (Mecmesin), hand tools.

Relevant Coursework

Soft Robotics; Advanced Dynamics; Ethics and Communication in Robotics and AI Research; Foundations in Robotics; Advanced Mechanics of Deformable Bodies; Mechatronic System Design; Design of Experiments; Engineering Vibrations; Automatic Feedback Control; Instrumentation and Measurement Systems.

Campus and Community Involvement

Member, American Society of Mechanical Engineers	March 2015 – Present
WPI Video Game Orchestra	Nov 2024 – Present
WPI Tennis Club	Aug 2024 – Present
WPI Philharmonic Orchestra, 1st Violinist	Nov 2023 – Present
CSULB Long Beach Lunabotics, Mechanical Engineer	Sept 2020 – May 2022
CSULB Beach Launch Team, Avionics Engineer	Sept 2020 – May 2022
CSULB Bob Cole Symphony Orchestra, 2nd Violinist	Sept 2019 – March 2020
Rebuilding Together Solano County, Volunteer	Aug 2015 – Aug 2016